



The Return of RAM

New interpretations, serials, plays and even politics ensure Ram and the Ramayana stay embedded in the Indian psyche

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

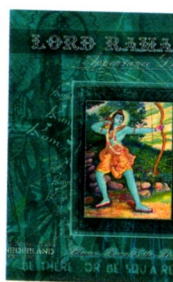
As one walks through the narrow lanes of Mylapore, Chennai, the lilting melody of P. Susheela's voice crooning, *Raman ethanai Raman adi...* (Ram, there are so many Rams my dear) drifts onto the streets. From the film *Lakshmi Kalyanam*, this song continues to symbolise the role of Ram in the popular imagination and in the arts, endlessly fascinating poets, dancers, musicians, scholars and filmmakers.

If Rajkumar Santoshi's Rs 100-crore adaptation of the Ramayana, starring Ajay Devgan, is on hold, Mani Ratnam's bilingual *Ravana* in Tamil



RAM

THE STORY OF RAM BY DEVDUTT PATTNAIK, PUBLISHED BY PENGUIN (LEFT); A POSTER OF A PERFORMANCE BASED ON RAM



and Hindi, starring Abhishek and Aishwarya Rai Bachchan and Govinda, is on a roll. Soon India will have both a Bollywood and a Hollywood version of the epic in hi-tech animation. Maya entertainment will produce the Indian version, *Ramayana—The Epic* directed by Chetan Desai. Due for an early 2009 release, the film has Manoj Bajpai, Juhi Chawla and Ashutosh Rana lending their voices to the characters. The Hollywood version from Liquid Comics and Mandalay Pictures, *Ramayan 3392 AD*, is a 21st century reimagining due for release in 2011.

It is this universal fascination for